HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

The Secret of the Copper Snake: Miracles, Amulets & Relying on Hashem

Given Monday 6 July 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem 8.5

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Kifayat al-Abidin) — Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam **Chapter:** Perek 8 (ביטחון — Bitachon and Reliance) — Part 5 **This Week:** Miracles — Can Anything Harm the Person of True Bitachon? · The Copper Snake Reinterpreted · Never Rely on Miracles · Spiritual Mortal Danger (Shmad) · Category 2 — Minor Harms (the Machloket with Rabbeinu Yonah) · Category 3 Begun — Basic Necessities · Two Great Questions

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Recap

- **Bitachon defined**: Hashem oversees all the regular intermediaries He set in the world and can change them at any time — so no going overboard in pursuit of wealth/health, no laziness, no arrogant reliance on miracles
- Bitachon does **not** contradict cause and effect — science is real, and Hashem oversees it
- **The five categories of use**: (1) avoiding extremely harmful situations, (2) avoiding minor harms, (3) attaining the essential, (4) attaining the important-but-not-essential, (5) attaining luxuries — each in physical and spiritual form
- **Prerequisite**: no employing bitachon without doing Hashem's will
- **Category 1 (begun last week)**: in serious danger — trust, Tehillim (91, 18), prayer, and every natural means

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PART 1 — Completing Category One: Miracles

The Principle — Nothing Can Harm the Person of True Bitachon

> **ודע לך לדעת שאם גדלה צדקתו של אדם וטובים מעשיו, ובטחונו בשם יתעלה בכל ענייניו נכון ונאות... עד שזרח אורו עליו וחש בקרבתו אליו ובגודל השגחתו עליו — אז אין שליטה עליו לגורמים המזיקים**

If a person's righteousness is great, his conduct good, his reliance on Hashem complete — living in love of Hashem, feeling His closeness and His hashgacha constantly — **then the harmful forces have no power over him.**

The Verses

Verse	Meaning
כי תעבור במים אתך אני, ובנהרות לא ישטפוך (Yeshayahu)	Crossing water and rivers — you will not drown
כי תלך במו אש לא תכוה, ולהבה לא תבער בך	Walking through fire — it will not singe or consume you
על שחל ופתן תדרוך, תרמוס כפיר ותנין	You will tread on lions and vipers

(Caveat coming below: this is theoretical — never put yourself in danger.)

The Copper Snake — A Stunning Reinterpretation (Parshat Chukat)

The Standard Reading (how we've always read it)

The people complain → Hashem sends the snakes → many die → they do teshuvah and beg Moshe to pray → Moshe makes the copper snake on the banner → **the plague stops**, and anyone already bitten looks at it and is healed.

The Avi Ezer's Reading — The Snakes NEVER Stopped

והוא יתעלה לא הסיר את הנחשים — והיו נושכים אותם כשם שנשכום קודם Hashem did NOT remove the snakes. They continued biting the people after the teshuvah exactly as before!

Look at the verse itself:

והיה אם נשך הנחש את איש — והביט אל נחש הנחושת וחי *— "And it would be, if the snake BIT a man he would look at the copper snake and LIVE".*

The verse describes an **ongoing arrangement**: the biting continues; only the dying stops. Why?

כדי שידעו שפעולתם של נחשים שפועלים בהם היא רק עבור הסרת השגחתו מעליהם So that they would know that the snakes' power over them existed ONLY because His providence had been removed. Once trust in Hashem was restored — the same bites, from the same snakes, simply could not kill.

(Rabbi Kada: In all my life I never read the passage this way — and searching the commentators, I found no one else who says this — yet it appears to be the most straightforward reading of the verses. The snakebite doesn't determine death; the will of Hashem does.)

No Mystical Power in the Copper Snake

ואין סיבת הדבר איזה כוח מסתורי שבנחש, כמו שחשבו כופרים וסכלים מישראל

There was **no mystical power** in the copper snake — as heretics and fools imagined. The proof: generations later people began worshipping it —

וכתת נחש הנחושת אשר עשה משה, כי עד הימים ההם היו בני ישראל מקטרים לו, ויקרא לו נחושתן — **Chizkiyahu smashed it** (they had named it "Nechushtan" and were offering to it) **קיצץ נחש הנחושת והודו לו** — and the Sages praised him for it.

The same applies to **talismans and amulets** — the Rambam, and his son here following him, held there is **no value whatsoever** in amulets, strings, and charms. Completely false.

So What WAS the Copper Snake For? — The Mishnah

וכי נחש ממית או נחש מחיה? אלא: כל זמן שישראל מסתכלין כלפי מעלה ומשעבדין את לבם לאביהם שבשמים — היו מתרפאים, ואם לאו — היו נימוקים" *Does a snake kill or does a snake give life? Rather —" whenever Israel looked upward and subjugated their hearts to their Father in Heaven, they were healed; if not, they wasted away."*

The copper snake was an **external directing device** — not an intermediary (that would be avodah zarah!) — a tool to turn their attention and trust to Hakadosh Baruch Hu. When they looked and directed their hearts to Hashem — they lived.

The Gemara — Chanina ben Dosa and the Chavarbar

תנו רבנן: מעשה במקום אחד שהיה בו **חברבר** והיה מזיק את הבריות...

A venomous snake was killing people in a certain place. They told **Rabbi Chanina ben Dosa**. He said: *"Show me its hole."* He **placed his heel over the mouth of the hole** — the snake came out, bit him — **and the snake died.** He slung it over his shoulder, carried it to the Beit Midrash and said:

> **ראו בני — אין חברבר ממית, אלא החטא ממית"** *See, my sons — it is not the snake that kills; it is SIN that kills."*

At that moment they said:

> **אוי לו לאדם שפגע בו חברבר, ואוי לו לחברבר שפגע בו רבי חנינא בן דוסא"** *Woe to the man who meets a chavarbar — and woe to the chavarbar that meets Rabbi Chanina ben Dosa!"*

Many similar stories fill the Talmud. One who lacks understanding denies them; **one of firm religiosity, straight principles, and complete apprehension will understand and believe them.**

The Crucial Caveat — NEVER Rely on Miracles

והנסים והנפלאות הללו — אין אדם יכול להשליך חייו עליהם אם לא הורה לו עליהם [ה']

This is all **theory, not practice**. Even a prophet — all the more so we — is **forbidden to put himself in danger** without absolute necessity:

Figure	The Evidence
Shmuel	Told to anoint David: **איך אלך? ושמע שאול והרגני** — "How can I go? Shaul will hear and kill me!"
Moshe (master of the prophets)	fled from his own — **וינס משה מפניו** fled Pharaoh; and — **ויברח משה מפני פרעה** staff-turned-snake
Eliyahu	Fled for his life (וירץ... וימלט את נפשו)

The Torah and Chazal

build the parapet; do not bring bloodshed into your house — **ולא תשים דמים בביתך**

- Chazal prohibited many things on grounds of danger: **מים מגולים** (water left exposed overnight — lest a snake left venom) and the **nibbled melon** *(halachically, most poskim today permit exposed water indoors — hygiene aside — but the principle stands: the Sages built precautions so no one relies on miracles)*

לעולם אל יעמוד אדם במקום סכנה ויאמר עושין לי נס — שמא אין עושין לו נס, ואם עושין לו נס — מנכין לו מזכיותיו *Never stand in danger saying "a miracle will save me" — perhaps it won't; and if it does, it is deducted from your merits*

The Practical Ruling

אין צורך וגם אין רשות לאדם השומר את התורה כראוי להפליג בים... או לצאת במדבריות שהם בחזקת סכנה... כדי להרבות סחורה והון

One has **neither need nor permission** to sail dangerous seas or cross dangerous deserts **merely to amass more wealth** *(contemporary application: traveling to a dangerous country for a business deal — not correct)*. The only justification for such journeys: **fleeing an enemy or oppression.**

Don't Be Fooled by the Survivors

"!but many people take these risks and survive" — **ולא ישלה אדם את עצמו**

- If they are **not righteous** — Hashem is paying out their reward **in this world** (a terrible bargain)
- If they **are righteous** — this is exactly Chazal's warning: the miracle is **deducted from their merits**

The Spiritual Parallel — Mortal Danger to One's Religion (Shmad)

כשם שעלול אדם לסבול נזק בענייניו הגשמיים ולבוא לידי סכנת נפשות — כך עלול הוא לסבול נזק דתי ולבוא לידי סכנת הדת, כגון סכנת השמד

Just as the body can face mortal danger, the soul can face **religious mortal danger** — forced conversion, persecution *(which the Rambam himself lived through)*. If it happens, **it is a test and decree from Hashem**:

1. **Trust in Him and cleave to Him with all the heart** — and pray, like David: **אל תט לבי לדבר רע** ("do not incline my heart to an evil thing"), **אל תשליכני מלפניך**
2. **Make every effort to FLEE** — like the Tannaim and men of deed who fled the Greek persecutions and **hid in caves**
3. Or, where halacha requires — **give up one's life al Kiddush Hashem**, like **Chananyah, Mishael, and Azaryah, Daniel, and the Asarah Harugei Malchut** (whom we read about on Tisha B'Av) — according to the rules of **יהרג ואל יעבור / יעבור ואל יהרג** *(as the Rambam laid out in Iggeret HaShmad, which we learned over a year ago)*

End of Category One — in both its physical and spiritual forms.

PART 2 — Category Two: Minor Harms (הרחקת נזק בלתי חמור)

The Surprising Ruling — Don't Employ Bitachon for Trivial Annoyances

ועכשיו בנוגע לחלק השני — הרחקת נזק בלתי חמור, כגון פשפשים ופרעושים טורדים, או עגמת נפש בעניין פעוט... אין זה מן הראוי שיפעיל האדם את ביטחונו להרחקת הפגעים הפעוטים הללו — אלא אם כן נמנה הוא עם גדולי החסידים והנביאים

Annoying insects, fleas, minor distress, someone insulting you — **it is NOT appropriate to deploy bitachon for such trivial harms** — *unless* one is among the greatest of the pious and the prophets.

The Exceptions — Those Who Lived Supernaturally

Figure	The Story
Chanina ben Dosa	Caught in the rain: **כל העולם כולו בנחת — וחנינא בצער?** ("the whole world is at ease and Chanina suffers?") — **and the rain stopped** *(a normal person may not pray against rain that benefits everyone — let alone for so trivial a bother)*
Elisha	The youths taunted him on the way to Beit El — he prayed — **ותצאנה שתים דובים... ותבקענה מהם ארבעים ושני ילדים** (the bears mauled 42 of them)

For any **ordinary pious person to deploy bitachon this way is an audacity the mind cannot tolerate.** **וכל חסיד, וכל שכן סתם אדם כשר, אם יפעילו ביטחונם באלו — הרי זה אומץ לב שאין הדעת סובלתו**

The Logic (from Prerequisite 2, last week)

Bitachon's highest use is **for Hashem's will**, not merely our own comfort. For essentials — fine. But to enlist trust-in-God for one's own **trivial** comfort? Only one whose every fiber serves Hashem — for whom even a mosquito genuinely impedes avodat Hashem — may do so.

May One Still PRAY About Small Things?

Yes. One may pray to Hashem about anything (the mosquito keeping you up at night). The Avi Ezer's point is narrower: do not deploy **BITACHON** — the confident *reliance* "Hashem, I trust You WILL remove this" — for trivial personal matters. Prayer, yes; confident reliance as a claim, no.

The Machloket — Rabbeinu Yonah Says the OPPOSITE

Rabbeinu Yonah on Mishlei 3:6 — **בכל דרכיך דעהו** ("In all your ways know Him"):

בכל פועל שתבקש לעשות זכור את ה' יתברך וקווה אליו שיצליחך... **כי יש מי שבוטח בה' יתברך בכלל אך לא ישיב עניין הביטחון אל לבו בפרטים** — על כן אמר בכל דרכיך דעהו: **בכל פרטי מעשיך**

Some trust Hashem for **big things** (setting sail on a business venture) but forget Him in **small things** (will the weather hold on my trip?) — because it seems too minor to bother. **Therefore the verse says: know Him in ALL your ways — in matters great and SMALL.**

The Machloket Crystallized

	Avi Ezer (Rabbi Avraham)	Rabbeinu Yonah
Bitachon for minor personal matters	**Inappropriate** — don't make God the solver of your trivial issues (unless you are of the greatest chassidim)	**Required** — בכל דרכיך דעהו: trust Him even for the fly bothering you

(One might try to resolve it — Rabbeinu Yonah speaks of prayer, not bitachon? — but examining his words inside, he speaks explicitly of bitachon. It is a genuine machloket Rishonim.)

When Minor Becomes Major

ושוב אפשר שהנזק הבלתי חמור הזה... ייהפך לחמור

If the "minor" harm compounds — e.g., a sensitive, hot-tempered person whose sleep is stolen night after night by the insects until fever and illness result — **it reverts to Category One** (serious harm), with all its rules: full bitachon, prayer, and every natural means.

Minor Harms in SPIRITUAL Matters — The Rule Reverses

וכן הנזק הפעוט בענייני הדת — צריך להתחשב בו שמא יארע נזק גדול... כי רגלים לדבר שכמה מענייני הדת... מביאה עשייתם לידי תוצאות גדולות ועל הזנחתם לתוצאות גדולות

For **spiritual** matters, even MINOR breaches demand bitachon — because small spiritual lapses **compound into great consequences**:

> **הוי זהיר במצוה קלה כבמצוה חמורה, שאין אתה יודע מתן שכרן של מצוות** — Be careful with a "light" mitzvah as with a weighty one
>
> **שכר מצוה מצוה, ושכר עבירה עבירה** — one mitzvah draws another; one sin draws another

Therefore:

> **חייב כל אדם להשתדל להתאמץ להתפלל לשם יתעלה, לבקש ממנו רחמים, לבטוח בו שיצילנו מכל נזק דתי** — like David **trust Hashem to save you even from small spiritual failures**. Pray and **חקרני אל ודע לבבי, בחנני ודע שרעפי, וראה אם דרך עוצב בי** ("Search me, God... see if there is any offensive way in me").

The Example — Being Pressured to Tell a Lie

In the grand scheme it's "minor" (not Shabbat desecration, not conversion). By the physical-matters logic, bitachon would be inappropriate. **But in spiritual matters — deploy bitachon even here.** Why? Because one small lie breeds bigger ones — *"Oh what a tangled web we weave, when first we practise to deceive"* (Sir Walter Scott, 1808). Small spiritual things grow.

End of Category Two.

PART 3 — Category Three Begun: Bitachon for Basic Necessities

ואשר לחלק השלישי — דהיינו השגת תועלת הכרחית, כגון מזונות ומלבושים הכרחיים וכיוצא בזה

For **essential needs** — basic food, basic clothing, basic shelter — employing bitachon is **absolutely appropriate.** The model is **Yaakov Avinu**:

והוא שהצטמצם בהכרחי לבד — לחם לאכול ובגד ללבוש — ויבטח בו יתעלה שיתן לו זה

Yaakov confined his request to the essentials only — **לחם לאכול ובגד ללבוש** — and trusted Hashem to grant it. And: **work a normal job** as Yaakov shepherded Lavan's flock — **with the inner recognition that parnasah comes from Hashem.**

Rabbeinu Bachya (on Yaakov's request)

זאת שאלת הצדיקים מאת השם: לא ישאלו מותרות, רק דבר הכרחי בלבד *This is the request of the righteous: they do not ask for luxuries — only what is essential.*

The Supporting Verses — Hashem Feeds All

Verse	Point
נותן לחם לכל בשר	He gives bread to all flesh
כולם אליך ישברון לתת אכלם בעתו	All hope to You to give their food in its time
עיני כל אליך ישברו ואתה נותן להם את אכלם בעתו	*(said before HaMotzi)* The eyes of all look to You
נותן לבהמה לחמה, לבני עורב אשר יקראו	He feeds the animals, even the young ravens
זן מקרני ראמים ועד ביצי כינים (Chazal)	He sustains from the horns of the wild ox to the eggs of lice

("With the baby comes the bread.")

The Two Great Questions (Left for Next Time)

שתי שאלות חיוניות שאפשר שיתעוררו אצל בעל הביטחון

Question 1 — If Hashem Feeds Even the Lice, Why Bitachon? Why Work?

The verses just quoted say Hashem grants sustenance **even to creatures without da'at** (the eggs of lice!). If so —

> **מה תועלת אפוא בביטחון בעניין הפרנסה? הלא בין אם יבטח האדם ובין לא יבטח, בין ישתדל במלאכה ובין לא ישתדל — מכל מקום תבוא הפרנסה!** Whether you trust or don't trust, work or don't work — the sustenance comes anyway? Then what advantage has the botei'ach over the non-botei'ach — and why work at all?

Question 2 — Is Bitachon Natural or Praiseworthy? (It Can't Be Both)

The verse says **עיני כל אליך ישברו** — *everyone's* eyes look hopefully to You — implying trust in Hashem is **natural and universal**. But then:

- Why do other verses **praise** the one who trusts (**אשרי הגבר אשר שם ה' מבטחו**)?
- And **condemn** the one who doesn't (**הנה הגבר לא ישים אלהים מעוזו**)?

If bitachon is universal — praise is meaningless. If only some have it — the verse claiming all do seems contradicted. *(And empirically — not everyone does trust in Hashem.)*

The answers — next shiur.

Summary

Category One Completed — Miracles

- The person of **complete** bitachon cannot be harmed (fire, water, snakes) — proven by the **copper snake**, radically reread: **the snakes never stopped biting; the deaths stopped** — teaching that the snake doesn't kill, the removal of hashgacha kills (אין חברבר ממית אלא החטא ממית — Chanina ben Dosa)
- The copper snake had **no mystical power** (Chizkiyahu smashed it; amulets are worthless) — it was a device to direct hearts to Heaven
- **But never rely on miracles**: Shmuel, Moshe, and Eliyahu all fled danger; Chazal built safety fences; a miracle **deducts from one's merits**; no permission to court danger for wealth
- **Spiritual Category One = shmad**: trust, pray, flee (the caves) — or, where halacha demands, Kiddush Hashem

Category Two — Minor Harms

- **Physical**: do NOT deploy bitachon for trivial annoyances (insects, insults) — unless you are a Chanina ben Dosa or Elisha. *(Prayer is fine; confident reliance is not.)* — **Against Rabbeinu Yonah**, who requires bitachon בכל דרכיך, even in the small
- If minor harm compounds into serious harm → back to Category One
- **Spiritual**: the rule REVERSES — deploy bitachon even for the smallest spiritual danger, because small breaches compound (שכר עבירה עבירה)

Category Three Begun — Essentials

- For basic food/clothing/shelter: bitachon is right and proper — the model of **Yaakov** (לחם לאכול ובגד ללבוש), working while knowing parnasah is from Hashem
- **Two questions pending**: (1) if Hashem feeds even the lice, why bitachon and why work? (2) is bitachon natural (עיני כל) or praiseworthy (אשרי הגבר) — it can't be both?

Schedule Note

To finish the bitachon section before the Tisha B'Av break (two Mondays remain): proposal to hold **Thursday's shiur as HaMaspik** (in place of Hilchot Shabbat) if five people can attend — then the two Mondays — completing the topic before the break. *(Tomorrow: Moreh as usual.)*

B'Ezrat Hashem

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